תַּקָּנַת הַשָּׁבִין

Takanas HaShavin

An Interlinear Translation
with Annotated Footnotes

Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen Rabinowitz of Lublin
(1823–1900)

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VOLUME I

כְּרֶךְ א · סִימָנִים א–י

Introduction through Siman 10

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Takanas HaShavin

Volume I · Introduction through Siman 10

This volume presents the Introduction and Simanim 1–10 of Takanas HaShavin, Rabbi Tzadok HaKohen’s work on teshuvah. The original Hebrew is presented in close, phrase-by-phrase sequence with an English translation and explanatory source footnotes.

The footnotes draw on primary sources, including the Gemara, Midrashim, Zohar, other writings of Rabbi Tzadok, and the teachings of the Izhbitz–Radzin school.

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Introduction · הַקְדָּמָה

The Seven Praises of Teshuvah and the Seven Lower Sefiros

Se'if 1 · סעיף א

The theme: The whole work hangs on the Gemara's seven statements in praise of teshuvah (Yoma 86). Teshuvah is drawn from the binah of the heart — which is why the Men of the Great Assembly fixed it after "binah" in the blessings. The seven praises correspond to the seven lower sefiros, the stages by which anything passes from the heart's understanding into completed act; hence seven simanim, one per praise.

בְּסִיַּעְתָּא דִּשְׁמַיָּא — **With the help of Heaven,** קוּנְטְרֵס קְרָאתִיו — **a pamphlet I have entitled** תַּקָּנַת הַשָּׁבִין — **"The Remedy of the Returners" —** לְקוּטֵי עִנְיְנֵי תְּשׁוּבָה — **compilations of themes of repentance.** לְשָׁבֵי פֶּשַׁע בְּיַעֲקֹב — **for those who turn back from transgression in Jacob.**

בְּיוֹמָא (פ״ו עַמּוּד א׳ וְעַמּוּד ב׳): — **In Yoma (86a-b):** "גְּדוֹלָה תְּשׁוּבָה וְכוּ׳", — **"Great is repentance, etc.";** עַיֵּין שָׁם — **examine there.** שֶׁבַע מֵימְרוֹת בִּגְדוּלַּת וּמַעֲלַת הַתְּשׁוּבָה[1] — **There are seven statements regarding the greatness and virtue of repentance.** וְיָדוּעַ דְּהַתְּשׁוּבָה נִמְשֶׁךְ מֵהַבִּינָה שֶׁבַּלֵּב — **And it is known that repentance is drawn from understanding (Binah) in the heart,**

כְּמוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: "וּלְבָבוֹ יָבִין וְשָׁב",[2] — **as it is stated (Isaiah 6:10): "And its heart will understand, and it will return,"** דְּעַל כֵּן אֲמָרִינַן תְּשׁוּבָה אַחַר בִּינָה — **for which reason we state that repentance follows understanding,** (י״ז עַמּוּד ב׳) כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בִּמְגִלָּה.[3] — **as they said in Megillah (17b).** וְנוֹדָע בִּיצִיאַת דָּבָר לְפוֹעַל דְּשֶׁבַע מַדְרֵגוֹת הֵם — **And it is recognized that there are seven gradations,** מִבִּינַת הַלֵּב עַד גְּמַר הַפְּעֻלָּה — **in bringing a matter into actuality from understanding in the heart until the culmination of the action,**

שֶׁהֵם סוֹד שֶׁבַע סְפִירוֹת חֶסֶד, גְּבוּרָה, תִּפְאֶרֶת, נֶצַח, הוֹד, יְסוֹד, מַלְכוּת — **which are the mystical secret of the seven sefirot: Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, Hod, Yesod, and Malchut,** וְנֶגְדָּם הוּא כָּל מִסְפַּר שֶׁבַע כַּיְּדוּעַ,[4] — **and corresponding to them is every instance of the number seven as is**

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1 **Yoma 86a**–b: Seven statements in praise of teshuvah: (a) "Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world"; (b) "Great is teshuvah, for it reaches the Throne of Glory"; (c) "Great is teshuvah, for it overrides a Torah prohibition"; (d) "Great is teshuvah, for it hastens the redemption"; (e) "Great is teshuvah, for it turns willful sins into inadvertent ones — or into merits"; (f) "Great is teshuvah, for it lengthens a person's days and years"; (g) "Great is teshuvah, for one individual who repents, he and the whole world are forgiven." R' Tzadok reads the seven as corresponding to the seven lower *sefiros*, and organizes his opening discussion accordingly.
Sources: Yoma 86a

2 **Yeshayah 6:10**: part of Yeshayah's inaugural vision (ch. 6). After Israel has persisted in sin, the prophet is charged: "הַשְׁמֵן לֵב הָעָם הַזֶּה וְאָזְנָיו הַכְבֵּד וְעֵינָיו הָשַׁע, פֶּן יִרְאֶה בְעֵינָיו וּבְאָזְנָיו יִשְׁמָע וּלְבָבוֹ יָבִין וְשָׁב וְרָפָא לוֹ" — "Make the heart of this people fat, and their ears heavy, and seal their eyes, lest they see with their eyes and hear with their ears and their heart understand, and they return and be healed." Rashi explains "*hashmen*" as a continuous hardening (of the form "*hachbed es libo*," **Shemos 8:11**), and that "lest they see with their eyes and their heart understand and return, and it be their healing" describes the very outcome the people had closed their hearts against. R' Tzadok draws on the order of the verse — first "their heart shall *understand yavin*," then "and *return va-shav*" — that teshuvah is drawn from the *binah* of the heart; this is why the Men of the Great Assembly set the blessing of *teshuvah* after *binah* in the Amidah (**Megillah 17b**), and why the "healing *ve-rafa lo*" that follows is the healing of forgiveness.
Sources: Yeshayah 6:10 · Megillah 17b

3 **Megillah 17b**: "Why did the Men of the Great Assembly see fit to place teshuvah after binah in the *Amidah*? Because it is written, 'and his heart shall understand and return and be healed' (**Yeshayah 6:10**)." The Gemara then distinguishes the "healing" of forgiveness (which follows teshuvah directly) from bodily healing (which follows forgiveness): "that is not the healing of ailments but the healing of forgiveness."
Sources: Megillah 17b · Yeshayah 6:10

4 Cf. **Pesachim 54a** (and **Nedarim 39b**): teshuvah is among the *seven things created before the world* —

known. וְכֵן שֶׁבַע גְּדוּלּוֹת אֵלּוּ דִּתְשׁוּבָה[5] — **and likewise these seven declarations of greatness concerning repentance.**

"Torah, teshuvah, Gan Eden, Gehinnom, the Throne of Glory, the Beis HaMikdash, and the name of Mashiach." The list itself traces this work's arc: teshuvah (rooted in *Binah*) that reaches *the Throne of Glory* (Siman 2) and culminates in *the name of Mashiach* (Siman 4).

Sources: Pesachim 54a

5 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §100**): "Teshuvah means that one *returns the very thing to Hashem* — that is, he recognizes that Hashem effects everything, and that His power was present even in the *thought* before it was formed in a man's heart (**Bereishis Rabbah 9**); it emerges that Hashem gave him the strength even within the sin, and through this, after complete teshuvah, he merits that willful sins become merits, for this too was Hashem's will." This is the inner engine of the "seven greatnesses" the preamble sets out: teshuvah is no mere remorse but the restoring of the strayed thing to its Source — and because the very power spent on the sin was God-given, that power, turned back, becomes the ladder by which teshuvah "reaches the Throne."

R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §159**): "An individual who repents is forgiven, and the whole world with him (**Yoma 86b**) — and how is such forgiveness possible? Only that he arouses in their hearts too the stirrings of teshuvah; and not everyone who wishes to make himself such an 'individual' can do so, for it has not yet been — only *Mashiach ben David* will be so, for his soul must include all souls, since otherwise his own thoughts of teshuvah could not generate thoughts of teshuvah in one whose soul has no connection to his." This marks the outermost reach of the "greatness of teshuvah" that heads the work: from the very same Yoma 86 sugya, a single true penitent can draw a whole world after him — the summit toward which the seven rungs ascend.

Sources: Tzidkas HaTzadik §100 · Bereishis Rabbah 9 · Tzidkas HaTzadik §159 · Yoma 86b

Siman 1 · סימן א

Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world

גדולה תשובה שמביאה רפואה לעולם.

Se'if 1 · סעיף א

The theme: The "healing" of this first rung is the healing of forgiveness, not bodily healing — a rectification going forward only. The moment a person's heart stirs to return he is already called a complete tzaddik, before he has performed any labor upon the past. But a trace remains, as with a healed baal mum, or a convert whose earlier state is not wholly uprooted.

(א) שֶׁמְּבִיאָה רְפוּאָה לָעוֹלָם — **Repentance brings healing to the world,** וְנִרְאֶה לִי דְּהַיְינוּ רְפוּאָה כְּלִישְׁנֵיהּ דִּקְרָא: דִּסְלִיחָה — **and it appears to me that this refers to the healing of forgiveness,** אֶרְפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם"",[6] — **matching the language of the verse (Hosea 14:5): "I will heal their backsliding,"** דְּמְבוֹאָר דְּקָאֵי אַמְּשׁוּבָה[7] — **since it is clear that it refers to wayward backsliding.** וּדְלֹא כְּמַהַרְשָׁ"א בְּחִדּוּשֵׁי אַגָּדוֹת — **and not as the Maharsha explained in Chiddushei Aggadot.**

וְהָא דְּלָא מַיְיתֵי מִן "וְשַׁב וְרָפָא לוֹ", — **And regarding why the Gemara did not cite the verse (Isaiah 6:10): "And he will return and be healed,"** דְּשָׁם כְּתִיב "לוֹ" לְשׁוֹן יָחִיד — **because there it is written "to him," in the singular,** וְהָכִי דַּיֵּיק "לָעוֹלָם — **" and thus it precisely deduces that it brings healing "to the world"** מִדְּפָתַח בְּלָשׁוֹן רַבִּים וְסַיֵּים בְּלָשׁוֹן יָחִיד — **from the fact that the verse opens in the plural ("their backsliding") and concludes in the singular ("My anger has turned**

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6 **Hoshea 14:5**: the climactic verse of the prophet's call to teshuvah (ch. 14, "*Shuvah Yisrael*," read as the haftarah of Shabbos Shuvah): "אֶרְפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם, אֹהֲבֵם נְדָבָה, כִּי שָׁב אַפִּי מִמֶּנּוּ" — "I will heal their backsliding, I will love them freely, for My anger has turned away from him." Rashi (from Tanchuma, Ekev): "once they say the words of teshuvah before Me, I will heal their backsliding *meshuvah* and love them with a generous spirit — though they are not worthy of the love, I will freely bestow it — for My anger has turned from them." R' Tzadok adduces this as the source that the "healing" of which the Gemara speaks (**Yoma 86a**, "great is teshuvah, for it brings healing") is the healing of *forgiveness*: "*meshuvah*" means backsliding sin, and it is precisely this that is "healed."

7 Chassidic parallels — the verse itself becomes a map of the first movement of teshuvah. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Prophets, **Hoshea 14:1**, reads the whole passage beginning "Ashur lo yoshienu" as Israel's surrender of every claim to spiritual self-sufficiency. Good deeds, zerizus, yirah, and even fiery ahavah are not things in which a person can finally boast; the decisive point is the "kol demamah dakah," the quiet Divine seal in the heart that the present movement truly accords with Hashem's will. The Divine response is then precisely, "ארפא משובתם אוהבם נדבה כי שב אפי ממנו" — "I will heal their backsliding... for My anger has turned from him," which the Mei HaShiloach explains as the removal of Divine anger from Israel. This fits R' Tzadok's insistence that the first refuah is the refuah of selichah: before the past has been transformed, the relationship has already been reopened and the anger has turned away. Sefas Emes, **Rosh HaShanah 25:4**, develops the next words, "אוהבם נדבה." There is an ahavah dependent upon conduct, which can be obscured when conduct fails, and there is the essential love of Israel because "chelek Hashem amo," an ahavah she-einah teluyah badavar. Sin can conceal the soul's revelation, but teshuvah reawakens it; hence "ארפא משובתם" is followed by "אוהבם נדבה." In the language of the Sefas Emes, the healing is not merely the cancellation of a punishment but the re-emergence of the neshama-level bond that the aveirah had hidden. This supplies a Chassidic basis for R' Tzadok's distinction between a wound that has been healed and the deeper root that was never destroyed. **Tanya, Likkutei Amarim ch. 39** (39:19 in Sefaria's segmentation), explicitly invokes the same ma'amar, "teshuvah brings healing to the world," in a strikingly concrete way: Torah learned with an ulterior motive can be held temporarily in exile within kelipas nogah, " עד אשר יעשה תשובה שמביאה רפואה לעולם, שבשובו אל ה' גם תורתו שבה עמו" — until he does teshuvah, which brings healing to the world; when he returns to Hashem, his Torah returns with him. The "world" healed by teshuvah thus includes the person's own earlier Torah and avodah: acts that were spiritually displaced are drawn back with the returning person. This is already a bridge from the first rung — healing from now on — toward the later rungs in which the past itself is recovered.

from him”). כִּדְדָיֵיק הָרִי״ף (רַבִּי יֹאשִׁיָּהוּ פִּינְטוֹ) בְּעֵין יַעֲקֹב, יְעַיֵּין שָׁם — **as deduced by the Rif (Rabbi Yoshiyahu Pinto) in Ein Yaakov, examine there.**

וּבְנֻסַּחַת גְּמָרָא שֶׁלְּפָנֵינוּ אִיתָא "רְפוּאוֹת" לְשׁוֹן רַבִּים — **And in the text of the Gemara before us it reads “healings” in the plural,** וְאִם הוּא נֻסְחָא דַּיְוקָנִית — **and if this is an exact textual reading,** יֵשׁ לוֹמַר דְּתַרְתֵּי קָאָמַר — **it can be said that it conveys two things:** רְפוּאַת הַנֶּפֶשׁ וּרְפוּאַת הַגּוּף — **healing of the soul and healing of the body,** דְּהָא בְּהָא תַּלְיָא — **for one is dependent on the other,**

כְּמוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: "הַסּוֹלֵחַ לְכָל עֲוֹנֵכִי, הָרֹפֵא לְכָל תַּחֲלוּאֵיכִי", — **as it is stated (Psalms 103:3): “Who forgives all your iniquity, Who heals all your diseases,”** (י״ז עַמּוּד ב׳) וְכִדְאִיתָא בִּמְגִלָּה שָׁם. — **and as brought in Megillah there (17b).** דְּכָל חֲלָיֵי הַגּוּף שֶׁל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֵינָם בְּמִקָּרֶה כְּלָל — **For all physical illnesses of the Jewish people are not incidental at all,** רַק מַקְבִּילִים מַמָּשׁ לְחֳלָיֵי הַנֶּפֶשׁ, — **rather they correspond directly to the maladies of the soul,** כְּמִפֹּרָשׁ בַּתּוֹרָה כַּמָּה פְּעָמִים — **as explicitly stated in the Torah several times.**

וּמִיָּד שֶׁמִּתְרַפֵּא הַנֶּפֶשׁ גַּם הַגּוּף מִתְרַפֵּא[8] — **and immediately when the soul is healed, the body is also healed.** וּמַה שֶּׁכָּתַב מַהַרְשָׁ״א דַּעֲדַיִן לֹא נִסְלַח, עַיֵּין שָׁם, לֵיתָא — **And what the Maharsha wrote, that it has not yet been forgiven, see there, is not so,** דְּמִפֹּרָשׁ בִּמְגִלָּה שָׁם דִּרְפוּאָה דְּסִלּוּחָה הוּא תֵּיכֶף אַחַר תְּשׁוּבָה — **for it is explicit in Megillah there that the healing of forgiveness occurs immediately following repentance,** וּרְפוּאָה דְּתַחֲלוּאִים הוּא אַחַר הַסִּלּוּחָה — **and the healing of physical sicknesses comes after forgiveness.** לֹא מְקַמֵּי הָכִי כְּלָל[9] — **not prior to it at all.**

וּמַה שֶּׁכָּתַב דְּ"מְשׁוּבָתָם" מַשְׁמַע דַּעֲדַיִן מְקֻצַּת מְשׁוּבָתוֹ עָלָיו — **And what he wrote, that “their backsliding” implies that some of his waywardness still remains upon him,** אֵינוֹ בַּמַּשְׁמָע כְּלָל — **is not implied at all.** דְּמְשׁוּבָתָם שֶׁלְּעָבַר קָאָמַר — **for it refers to their backsliding of the past.** וְנִרְאֶה דְּהוּא לָמַד זֶה מִלְּשׁוֹן רַשִׁ״י (דִּבּוּר הַמַּתְחִיל: "וּכְתִיב אֶרְפָּא וכוּ'", שְׁמְקֻצַּת וכוּ'), עַיֵּין שָׁם. — **And it appears that he derived this from the language of Rashi (heading: “And it is written ‘I will heal, etc.’”, that some, etc. see there).** וְרַשִׁ״י לֹא דַּיֵּיק מִמְּשׁוּבֹתֵיכֶם רַק מֵ"אֶרְפָּא", — **Yet Rashi did not deduce this from “your backslidings,” but rather from “I will heal,”**

דִּלְשׁוֹן רְפוּאָה מַשְׁמָעוֹ מִכָּאן וּלְהַבָּא — **for the term “healing” denotes from now and onward,** לֹא עֲקִירַת הַקּוֹדֶם כְּאִלּוּ אֵין מַכָּה — **not the uprooting of the past as though no wound had ever existed,** דְּאִם כֵּן רְפוּאָה לָמָּה — **for if so, why would healing be needed.** וּבְוַדַּאי זֶהוּ פְּשָׁט לְשׁוֹן רְפוּאָה — **and certainly this is the plain meaning of the term healing.** וְהוּא מַדְרֵגָה הָרִאשׁוֹנָה דִּתְשׁוּבָה — **– And this is the primary level of repentance –,**

לִרְפוּאוֹת מִכָּאן וְאֵילָךְ עַל כָּל פָּנִים — **to heal from now and onward at the very least.** וְכֵן הַסְּלִיחָה הוּא — **and likewise forgiveness applies only when sin is present.** רַק כְּשֶׁיֵּשׁ עָוֹן — **And this arrives immediately,** וְזֶה בָּא מִיָּד — **for “his heart will understand, and he returns,”** דְּ"לְבָבוֹ יָבִין וְשָׁב",

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8 **Tehillim 103:3**: “הַסֹּלֵחַ לְכָל עֲוֹנֵכִי, הָרֹפֵא לְכָל תַּחֲלָאֵיכִי” — “Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases” — from David’s psalm blessing Hashem for His benefactions to the soul. The two clauses run parallel — forgiveness of sin and healing of affliction — and the Gemara (**Megillah 17b**) derives from their order that the “healing” follows upon the “forgiveness”: first the iniquity is pardoned, then the ailments are healed. R’ Tzadok draws on this to explain the plural “*refu’os* healings” in the Gemara’s text as two — the healing of the *soul* (forgiveness) and the healing of the *body* — “for the one depends on the other,” the bodily ailments of Israel corresponding exactly to the ailments of the soul.

9 Maharsha, Chiddushei Aggados, **Yoma 86a**: questions why the Gemara did not prove that teshuvah brings healing “to the world” from “and he shall return and be healed to him” (**Yeshayah 6:10**), and suggests the verse speaks of literal healing, implying the sinner is not yet forgiven. R’ Tzadok rejects this: the Gemara in Megillah makes explicit that the “healing” here is forgiveness itself, which comes immediately upon teshuvah — the sinner is at once forgiven.

עַל יְדֵי הִרְהוּר תְּשׁוּבָה בְּלִבּוֹ נִקְרָא תֵּיכֶף צַדִּיק גָּמוּר[10] — **and through a contemplation of repentance in his heart he is immediately called completely righteous,**

כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּקִדּוּשִׁין (מ״ט עַמּוּד ב׳), — **as they stated in Kiddushin (49b).** אַף דְּלֹא עָשָׂה עֲדַיִן כָּל תִּיקּוּנֵי הַתְּשׁוּבָה[11] — **even though he has not yet performed all rectifications of repentance.** וְדַרְכֵי הַשָּׁבִים שֶׁזִּכְרוּ קַדְמוֹנִים — **And the pathways of the penitent mentioned by early authorities,** דְּהַכֹּל הוּא לְתַקֵּן הַקּוֹדֶם — **are entirely to rectify the past,** אֲבָל לִרְפוּאָה דִּלְהַבָּא — **however, regarding healing for the future,**

הוּא מִיָּד נַעֲשָׂה צַדִּיק גָּמוּר וְנִרְפָּא מִמּוּמוֹ,[12] — **he immediately becomes completely righteous and healed of his blemish,** רַק הוּא כְּבַעַל מוּם שֶׁמִּתְרַפֵּא שֶׁמְּקֻצָּת שְׁמוֹ עָלָיו[13] — **except that he is like a blemished person who has healed, who retains some of that designation upon him,** הַיְינוּ לְמִי שֶׁזּוֹכֵר הָרִאשׁוֹנוֹת יֵדַע שֶׁהָיָה בַּעַל מוּם — **meaning that whoever recalls former days knows he was once blemished,** רַק דְּנִתְרַפֵּא עַתָּה[14] — **only that he is healed now;** וְהוּא כְּגֵר שֶׁמִּתְגַּיֵּיר — **and he is like a convert who converts,**

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10 R' Tzadok — parallel (Dover Tzedek, Eruvin §4): "As it says in the first chapter of **Kiddushin (40a)**, that a *good thought* the Holy One joins to the deed — even if he merely thought to do a mitzvah and was prevented by circumstance, Scripture reckons it for him as though he did it; but an evil thought is not joined to the deed, for the transgression is only in the deed, and it is bounded, like this world, the world of action, whereas thought has no bound or limit at all." The se'if's point precisely: the mere *thought* of teshuvah makes one "a complete tzaddik" at once — for thought reaches beyond the bounded world of deed.

11 **Kiddushin 49b**: "If a man betroths a woman 'on condition that I am a righteous man' — even a completely wicked man — she is betrothed, for perhaps he had a thought of teshuvah in his mind." R' Tzadok adduces this as proof that a mere *thought* of teshuvah instantly renders one a "complete tzaddik," even before any of the labors of rectification. Tanya and Izhbitz on the instantaneous halachic force of hirhur teshuvah. **Tanya, Iggeres HaTeshuvah ch. 1** (1:7 in Sefaria's segmentation), defines the Torah's core mitzvah of teshuvah as "עזיבת החטא בלבד" — abandoning the sin — meaning that one "יגמור בלבו בלב שלם לבל ישוב עוד לכסלה," resolves wholeheartedly in his heart not to return to rebellion against His kingship. That formulation is especially apt here: **Kiddushin 49b** does not require that the man's biography already be visibly rewritten; the relevant question is whether, at that moment, the heart has truly turned. R' Tzadok's "complete tzaddik immediately" therefore accords with the Alter Rebbe's definition of the essential act of teshuvah as a present, inward resolution, while the further avodos of remorse, confession, fasting, and rectification address other dimensions of kapparah and purification. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Talmud, **Berachos 4a**:2, uses this very Kiddushin passage to describe the radical openness of human bechirah from one moment to the next. A person has, as it were, two open doors: "ברגע אחד יכול להשתנות ולהטיב דרכיו" — in a single moment he can change and improve his ways — and there is likewise an opening in the opposite direction. The Izhbitzer cites both halves of Kiddushin: "al menas she'ani tzaddik," perhaps he had a thought of teshuvah; and "al menas she'ani rasha," perhaps a dark thought entered him. The point is not to minimize deeds but to insist that the living point of choice is never frozen by yesterday's identity. This sharpens R' Tzadok's first rung of refuah: the past may still bear a scar, but the person's present spiritual status can turn immediately because the inner point of bechirah is alive now.

12 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §145**): "for the good, a good thought the Holy One joins to the deed" (**Kiddushin 40a**) — since "the soul You gave me is pure," a good intent is reckoned as an act; "and in teshuvah, which takes all the sinful thoughts and returns them to their root, the deeds automatically remain a *dead body* without vitality." This illuminates why a mere *thought* of teshuvah already makes one a "complete tzaddik": for the good, thought itself counts as deed, and teshuvah's thought withdraws the vitality the sins had drawn — leaving them lifeless — even before the labors of rectifying the past.

13 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §12**): teshuvah has two aspects — the future and the rectification of the past — and correspondingly two "healings." "It is established that atonement does not hold teshuvah back: for teshuvah, even if he only contemplated in his heart, *he is a complete tzaddik*" — yet this suffices only "for *terumah*, that which is lifted from the fully profane, to be at least within the class of a tzaddik; but for *kodshim* — one who wishes to sanctify himself and to be *holy* — he must also heal the past." R' Tzadok there anchors this in the Rambam's "change of name" (one no longer stands in the very time and state of his defilement) and in "were the Holy One not to help him he could not prevail." This illuminates the se'if's first rung: a stir of teshuvah instantly yields the "tzaddik" of forgiveness-going-forward, while the healed *baal mum*, of whom "a trace of his name remains," still awaits the further healing of the past.

14 **Yoma 86a**: "R' Chama b'Rabbi Chanina said: Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world, as it says, 'I will heal their backsliding, I will love them freely' (**Hoshea 14:5**)." He further contrasts "Return, backsliding children" (implying they were always wayward — teshuvah from love, which makes the very origin as innocent) with "I will heal your backslidings" (implying, as Rashi explains, one healed like a cured *baal mum* of whom "a trace of his name remains" — teshuvah from fear).

דְּאַף שֶׁהוּא כְּקָטָן שֶׁנּוֹלַד מִכָּאן וּלְהַבָּא — **for even though he is considered like a newborn child from now and onward.** מִכָּל מָקוֹם אֵין נֶעֱקָר הַקּוֹדֶם לְגַמְרֵי לִהְיוֹת כְּאֶזְרָח בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל — **nevertheless the past is not completely uprooted so as to be identical to a native-born Israelite.**

סעיף ב · Se'if 2

The theme: That lingering "trace" is the deficiency for which converts are said to be afflicted: their souls stood at Sinai, yet they did not enter at birth, only later. This root-lack is never fully healed in them. Hence the Torah's repeated warning against ona'as ha'ger — a true word about a real deficiency works upon a person and can change his very essence.

(ב) (מ״ח עַמּוּד ב׳) וּבִיבָמוֹת: — **And in Yevamot (48b): "** מִפְּנֵי מָה גֵּרִים מְעֻנִּין וְכוּלֵי? מִפְּנֵי שֶׁשָּׁהוּ וְכוּלֵי", — **"Why are converts afflicted, etc.? Because they delayed, etc.";** וְזֶה לֹא פָּלֵיג אַדְּרַבִּי יוֹסֵי שָׁם דְּהוּא כְּקָטָן שֶׁנּוֹלַד — **and this does not dispute Rabbi Yose there that he is like a newborn child,** וְאֵין לְהַעֲנִישׁ עַל עֲבֵירוֹת הַקּוֹדְמִים וְגַם לֹא יוֹעִיל וְזֶה הַטַּעַם שֶׁשָּׁהוּ[15] — **and that he is not to be punished for former sins, and moreover, this reason that they delayed would not explain**

אֲגַב שֶׁנִּתְגַּיֵּיר בְּבֵית דִּין בְּקָטְנוּתוֹ (וְכֵן קָשֶׁה אַתַּנָּא קַמָּא שָׁם), — **the case of a convert who converted in a court in his childhood ( ); — (and this is likewise difficult according to the first authority there);** אֲבָל לְעִנְיַן דִּינֵי שָׁמַיִם הַכַּוָּנָה עַל שָׁרְשׁוֹ. — **rather, regarding heavenly judgment, the intention relates to his essential spiritual root.** דְּאַף דְּבֶאֱמֶת גַּם נַפְשׁוֹת הַגֵּרִים הָיוּ בְּמַעֲמַד הַר סִינַי — **For even though the souls of converts were also present at the assembly of Mount Sinai,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּשַׁבָּת (קמ״ו ד״ישׁ עַמּוּד א׳): "מַזָּלֵיהוּ הָווּ", — **as they stated in Shabbat (146a): "Their constellations/spiritual souls were present,"**

וּמַזָּל הוּא שׁוֹרֶשׁ הָאָדָם[16] — **and the mazzal is the essential root of a person,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתַבְתִּי בְּמָקוֹם אַחֵר — **as I wrote elsewhere** (שָׁם נ״ג עַמּוּד ב׳): "אָדָם דְּאִית לֵיהּ מַזָּלָא", — **on what they said (there, 53b): "A man who possesses a spiritual guardian,"** וּבָנַי, חַיֵּי וּמְזוֹנֵי דְּתַלְיָא בְּמַזָּלָא (מוֹעֵד קָטָן כ״ח עַמּוּד א׳). — **and "children, life, and sustenance depend upon mazzal" (Moed Katan 28a).** אֲבָל מִכָּל מָקוֹם לֹא נִכְנְסוּ תַּחַת כַּנְפֵי הַשְּׁכִינָה מִיָּד בַּלֵּידָה רַק אַחַר כָּךְ, — **Yet nevertheless, they did not enter beneath the wings of the Shechinah immediately at birth, but only afterward,**

וְיֵשׁ לָהֶם חִסָּרוֹן זֶה בַּשֹּׁרֶשׁ שֶׁשָּׁהוּ וְכוּלֵי[17] — **and they bear this deficiency in their root, having delayed, etc.** וְזֶה הַחִסָּרוֹן לֹא נִתְרַפֵּא בָּם כְּלָל[18] — **and this deficiency has not been healed within**

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15 **Yevamos 48b**: "R' Yosei says: A convert who converts is like a newborn child and is not punished for what preceded. Then why are converts afflicted? Others say: because they delayed coming under the wings of the Shechinah." R' Tzadok reconciles the views: for practical punishment the convert is a "newborn," but with regard to the inner judgments of Heaven the "delay" marks a root-deficiency.

16 **Shabbos 146a**: the souls of future converts, too, were present at Sinai — "though they themselves were not there, their *mazal* guiding root was there." R' Tzadok: the *mazal* is a person's root, so the convert's soul was at Sinai; yet because he did not enter "at birth," a residual deficiency of "delay" remains.

17 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §246**): the souls of converts and servants, too, "were at Har Sinai — their *mazal* was there" (**Shabbos 146a**); "only there was a difference in the *hearing* — for the *erev rav* of that generation stood outside the pillar of cloud, and therefore 'their inclination is evil' (**Bava Metzia 59b**) and they are unrestrained… for their hearing at Sinai was through a *screen*." This parallel explains the screened hearing at Sinai. Its continuation, concerning the Hebrew servant's liberation at Yovel, says that his hidden soul-root cannot be severed from Hashem and that he then returns to the full name Israel. The present se'if's account of the worldly deficiency should be read with that distinction in view.

18 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Resisei Layla §41**): "A convert who converts is like a newborn (**Yevamos 22a**), and it effects that the past is forgotten and as though it is not; but they cannot rectify it so that the past too be *good* — for the root of the nations has no good in it, and the only good in it is that it transforms to be called by the name 'Israel,' and the name of the former nations is submerged from him. But the name 'Israel' is called upon even the most wicked in the world." Exactly the se'if's distinction: the convert's "delay" is a root-deficiency that is never truly healed, for the past cannot be made good — unlike a born Jew, whose root is good. Further

them at all. וְעַל כֵּן הִזְהִירָה תּוֹרָה עַל אוֹנָאַת הַגֵּר כַּמָּה פְּעָמִים — **Therefore the Torah issued warnings against verbal mistreatment of a convert several times,** שֶׁלֹּא יֹאמַר: "פֶּה שֶׁאָכַל נְבֵילוֹת וְכוּלֵי יָבוֹא לִלְמוֹד תּוֹרָה",[19] — **so that one does not say: "Shall a mouth that ate unkosher carcasses, etc. come to learn Torah?"** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּבָבָא מְצִיעָא (נח עמוד ב) — **as they said in Bava Metzia (58b).**

מִמַּשְׁמַע דְּהוּא דָּבָר וּמִדְּהָוְצְרַךְ לְהַזְהִיר — **And from the fact that it was necessary to warn against it,** שֶׁנִּיתַּן לֵיאָמֵר — **it implies that it is something plausible to be voiced.** דְּיֵשׁ בּוֹ מְשׁוּם אוֹנָאָה — **which constitutes hurtful verbal mistreatment.** דְּמַה שֶׁאֵינוֹ כְּלָל לֹא אִכְפַּת לְאָדָם אִם יֹאמְרוּ עָלָיו וּכְמוֹ שֶׁלֹּא אִכְפַּת לְיַעֲקֹב שֶׁהָיָה לוֹ אָח עֵשָׂו — **For regarding what is utterly false, a person does not care if people say it about him, just as Jacob was indifferent to having had a brother Esau,**

וּלְאַבְרָהָם שֶׁיֵּצְאוּ מִלָּבָן וְאִמָּהוֹת שֶׁיֵּצְאוּ מִתֶּרַח — **and the Matriarchs to having descended from Laban, and Abraham to having descended from Terah.** כֵּיוָן דְּאֵין לוֹ שׁוּם שַׁיָּיכוּת עוֹד לָזֶה — **since he no longer retains any connection to it.** (נ״ט עמוד ב׳) וְאָמְרוּ בָּבָא מְצִיעָא: — **And they said in Bava Metzia (59b): "** מִפְּנֵי מָה הִזְהִירָה תּוֹרָה עַל הַגֵּרִים? שֶׁסּוֹפָן רָע", — **"Why did the Torah issue warnings regarding converts? Because their inclination is bad,"**

עַל כֵּן רָצָה לוֹמַר שֶׁרַשָּׁן וְיסוֹדָן בָּאֱמֶת רָע — **meaning their root and foundation are in truth evil;** שֶׁיֵּשׁ בּוֹ דְּעִיקָּרָהּ הוּא כַּאֲשֶׁר אוֹמֵר דְּבַר אֱמֶת שֶׁבּוֹ צָרִיךְ אַזְהָרָה עַל אוֹנָאָתוֹ אוֹנָאַת דְּבָרִים גְּדוֹלָה — **therefore a warning is required against mistreating him. For its principal sting occurs when one mentions a true flaw within him, as it causes immense verbal pain.** אָז פּוֹעֵל בּוֹ הַרְבֵּה — **which then impacts him severely,**

עַד שֶׁיּוּכַל לִפְעוֹל בּוֹ עַל יְדֵי זֶה שִׁינּוּי בְּעַצְמוּתוֹ גַּם כֵּן עַל יְדֵי שֶׁמַּזְכִּיר הַחִסָּרוֹן שֶׁהוּא בָּאֱמֶת כֵּן בְּעַצְמוֹ[20] — **to the point that it can cause an internal breakdown in his very self as well, by reminding**

Chassidic background to "ger shenisgayer ke-katan shenolad." Kedushas Levi, Lech Lecha §37, takes the halachic principle with great literalness in explaining Avraham's break with Terach: the convert's former genealogical life no longer defines his spiritual identity; he is reborn into a new relation to Hashem. **Sefas Emes, Vayera 12:3**, similarly says that after the milah Avraham became "בריה חדשה כענין גר שנתגייר כקטן שנולד" — a new creature, like a convert who is as a newborn — and reads the new appearance of Hashem at the tent as the opening of an entirely new derech. Beis Yaakov on Torah, Chayei Sarah 24:1, adds an Ishbitz-Radzin nuance especially relevant to R' Tzadok's language of changing the former state. After the Akeidah, milah, and the ten nisyonos, Avraham was "נשתנה מהיפך להיפך, כענין גר שנתגייר" — changed from one opposite to the other, like a convert who must overturn an ingrained former way. Rebirth is therefore not only a juridical severance from the old past but the revelation of a newly ordered personality. At the same time, these sources help preserve R' Tzadok's distinction here. A ger can truly become a new person from this point onward, yet R' Tzadok asks a different, more radical question: can the earlier reality itself become good? **Resisei Layla §41** answers that for the ger the former world can be forgotten and submerged, but not transformed into a good Jewish root that was already present there. **Shem MiShmuel, Shabbos Shuvah 3:12**, compares the highest teshuvah to total immersion: when all the powers of the soul are swallowed into teshuvah one becomes "כקטן שנולד"; this is precisely why the analogy is so powerful for R' Tzadok — ordinary rebirth means a new beginning, whereas the higher Jewish power of teshuvah can ultimately go beyond beginning anew and recast the past itself.

19 **Bava Metzia 58b**: the Mishnah (***Bava Metzia* 4:10**) teaches — "Just as there is *ona'ah* wronging in buying and selling, so is there *ona'ah* in words. If one is a *baal teshuvah*, one may not say to him, 'Remember your earlier deeds'; and if he is the child of converts, one may not say to him, 'Remember the deeds of your ancestors' — as it is said, 'And a convert you shall not wrong, nor oppress him' (**Shemos 22:20**)." The Gemara adds: "If he was a convert who came to study Torah, one may not say to him, 'Shall a mouth that ate carcasses and *tereifos*, abominations and creeping things, come to study the Torah that was uttered from the mouth of the Almighty?'" This is the source R' Tzadok cites for the Torah's repeated warning against *ona'as ha-ger*.

20 **Bava Metzia 59b**: "It is taught — R' Eliezer the Great says: For what reason did the Torah warn in thirty-six places, and some say in forty-six places, concerning the convert? Because his inclination is evil (*mipnei she-soro ra*)" R' Tzadok's text reads *she-soran ra* (שֶׁסּוֹרָן רַע). The Gemara continues (R' Nassan): "'And a convert you shall not wrong, nor oppress him, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt' — a blemish that is in you, do not ascribe to your fellow (*mum she-becha al tomar la-chavercha*)." This is precisely R' Tzadok's point here: verbal wronging "works upon" a person only because it names a real deficiency in his root.

him of the defect that is genuinely present in his essence; וְכָךְ קִבַּלְתִּי וְאֵין כָּאן מְקוֹמוֹ.[21] — **and so I have received, and this is not the place to elaborate.**

סעיף ג · Se'if 3

The theme: The same caution extends to the baal teshuvah: "do not say to him, remember your former deeds." At teshuvah's beginning the past is not yet visibly rectified, so the reminder still stings. David, who raised up the yoke of teshuvah, was pained by it — and that his sin had been rectified retroactively was not made known in his own lifetime.

(ג) וַחֲכָמֵינוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה הוֹסִיפוּ בַּמִּשְׁנָה (שָׁם נ״ח עַמּוּד ב׳) — **And our Sages of blessed memory added in the Mishnah (there, 58b)** "גַּם לְבַעַל תְּשׁוּבָה לֹא יֹאמַר: "זְכֹר מַעֲשֶׂיךָ הָרִאשׁוֹנִים", — **even to a penitent, one must not say: "Remember your former deeds,"** אַף דְּחַטָּאֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֵינָם בְּעֶצֶם — **even though the sins of Israel are not part of their essential nature.** וְסוֹף הַתְּשׁוּבָה לְתַקֵּן הַקּוֹדֶם גַּם כֵּן לִהְיוֹת כְּאִלּוּ לֹא חָטָא כְּלָל — **and the culmination of repentance will rectify the past as well, so that it becomes as though he never sinned at all.** וְעַל כֵּן אֵין בָּזֶה אַזְהָרָה בַּתּוֹרָה — **Therefore there is no direct biblical prohibition regarding this,**

שֶׁהִיא מִצַּד הָאֱמֶת הַגָּמוּר לֹא שַׁיָּךְ אוֹנָאַת דְּבָרִים זוֹ כְּלָל — **for from the perspective of ultimate truth, such verbal grievance does not truly apply,** רַק חֲכָמִים הוֹסִיפוּהוּ, — **only that the Sages instituted it as an addition,** כִּי גַּם בְּבַעַל תְּשׁוּבָה תְּחִלַּת מַדְרֵגַת הַתְּשׁוּבָה — **because even with a penitent, at the initial rung of repentance.** אֵינוֹ נִגְלֶה עֲדַיִן תִּיקּוּן הַקּוֹדֶם[22] — **the rectification of the past is not yet openly revealed.** וְדָוִד הַמֶּלֶךְ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם, שֶׁהָיָה הַגֶּבֶר שֶׁהֵקִים עוֹלַת תְּשׁוּבָה שֶׁל — **And King David, peace be upon him, who was the man who established the yoke of repentance,**

כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בַּעֲבוֹדָה זָרָה (ה׳ עַמּוּד א׳), — **as they stated in Avodah Zarah (5a),** אָמְרוּ בָּבָא מְצִיעָא (נ״ט עַמּוּד א׳) — **they said in Bava Metzia (59a),** שֶׁהָיוּ מַלְבִּינִים פָּנָיו עַל יְדֵי הַזְכָּרַת הַחֵטְא — **that they would blanch his face in public by mentioning his sin.** עַד שֶׁאִם הָיוּ קוֹרְעִים בְּשָׂרוֹ וְכוּ'[23] — **to the point that had they torn his flesh, etc.** דְּהַלְבָּנַת פָּנִים הוּא עַל יְדֵי דְּאָזֵיל סוּמְקָא — **For the blanching of the face occurs because the redness departs.**

שֶׁהוּא הַדָּם שֶׁמִּמֶּנּוּ הַחֵטְא — **which is the blood from which sin arises.** כִּי "הַדָּם הוּא הַנָּפֶשׁ" — **For "the blood is the soul/life," as explicit in Scripture (Deuteronomy 12:23),** כְּמְפֹרָשׁ בַּקְּרָא — **and it refers to the animal,** וְקָאֵי אַבְּהֵמָה — כִּי הִיא נֶפֶשׁ הַבְּהֵמִית שֶׁבָּאָדָם גַּם כֵּן שֶׁמִּמֶּנָּה הַחֵטְא

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21 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §77**): "even a very great person, if there is a blemish in his family, one should not attach oneself to him — for even if it is tolerated on account of his own greatness, it will yet harm his offspring," as in "even were he like Yehoshua bin Nun, I would not give him my daughter" (**Yevamos 45a**); "yet from the side of the *crown of Torah* one need not be concerned about lineage, for the crown of Torah is set out for all… and the foundation of the Oral Torah is R' Akiva, who was of a family of converts." This illumines the se'if from the other side: the convert's root-blemish is real and reaches his seed, yet the crown of Torah wholly transcends it — a "mouth that ate carcasses" can become the very wellspring of the Oral Torah.

22 **Bava Metzia 58b**: the Mishnah (**Bava Metzia 4:10**), having taught that "just as there is *ona'ah* wronging in buying and selling, so is there *ona'ah* in words," rules: "if one is a *baal teshuvah*, one may not say to him, 'remember your former deeds.'" R' Tzadok notes that this clause — unlike the warning against wronging the convert — is not the Torah's own prohibition (for from the side of absolute truth a Jew's sin is not of his essence, and no true "wronging" applies); the Sages *added* it, because at the beginning of teshuvah the rectification of the past is not yet manifest.

23 **Avodah Zarah 5a**: "'The utterance of David son of Yishai, and the utterance of the man raised up on high *hukam al*' (**Shmuel II 23:1**) — the man who raised up the yoke *ulah* of teshuvah." **Bava Metzia 59a**: David said before the Holy One, "Master of the Universe, it is revealed before You that if they were to tear my flesh my blood would not flow to the ground from shame, for even when they are engaged in the laws of leprous marks and tents they say to me: David, one who comes upon a married woman — his death is by what? And I say to them: his death is by strangulation, yet he has a share in the World to Come; but one who publicly shames his fellow has no share in the World to Come."

since it likewise represents the animal soul in man from which sin stems, וְעַל נֶפֶשׁ זוֹ הוּא פְּשָׁטָיוּהּ דִּקְרָא דְּ"נֶפֶשׁ כִּי תֶחֱטָא". — **and upon this soul rests the plain meaning of the verse "when a soul sins."**

וְכֵן אִיתָא בָּבָא בַּתְרָא (נ״ח עַמּוּד ב׳): "בְּרֵישׁ כָּל מַרְעִין אֲנָא דָם".[24] — **And so it is stated in Bava Batra (58b): "At the head of all illnesses am I, blood."** וְעַל כֵּן בְּהַזְכָּרַת הַחֵטְא, כְּשֶׁעֲדַיִן לֹא נִתְקַן הַקּוֹדֶם, נִבְלָע דָּמוֹ בְּתוֹכוֹ.[25] — **Therefore, upon the mention of sin when the past has not yet been rectified, his blood drains inward.** וְדָוִד הַמֶּלֶךְ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הוּא הַתְחָלַת מַדְרֵגוֹת הַתְּשׁוּבָה שֶׁהוּא הָרְפוּאָה לְהַבָּא[26] — **And King David, peace be upon him, represents the beginning levels of repentance, which is healing for the future,** דְּעַל זֶה נִתְבַּשֵּׂר: "גַּם ה' הֶעֱבִיר חַטָּאתְךָ לֹא תָמוּת". — **concerning which he was told (II Samuel 12:13): "Hashem also has remitted your sin; you shall not die.",**

אֲבָל לִהְיוֹת נִתְקָן לְשֶׁעָבַר[27] — **However, to be fully rectified retroactively for the past,** שֶׁלֹּא יִהְיֶה לוֹ דָּבָר זֶה לֹא יֵדָעוּ בּוּשָׁה עוֹד בָּזֶה כְּלָל — **such that he would no longer suffer shame in this at all,**

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24 **Bava Basra 58b**: "ברישׁ כל מרעין – אנא דם" — "At the head of all illnesses am I — blood." The Gemara records this as the corrected wording of an inscription; it is not a statement attributed to Shmuel. Rashbam explains: "כל תחלואי האדם על הדם הם שמתרבה עליו" — "All a person's ailments are on account of the blood that increases in him" (**Rashbam, ad loc.**). R' Tzadok links the "blood" (the seat of the animal soul and of sin) to the "whitening of the face" (the draining of red) that shame produces when an unrectified sin is recalled.

25 The same daf continues (**Bava Metzia 58b**–59a): "whoever whitens the face of his fellow in public is as though he sheds blood" — Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak observing, "we see that the red departs *azil sumka* and pallor comes." This is R' Tzadok's source for reading the "whitening of the face" as the *departing of the red*, i.e. of the blood — "the blood is the soul," the animal soul that is the seat of sin — so that at the mention of an as-yet-unrectified sin the penitent's blood is "swallowed within him."

26 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Resisei Layla §28**): "This is the rung of David, who 'raised up the yoke of teshuvah' — for although he went where he went and sank where he sank, he can return to his root and his place in holiness, at the highest rung; as is known to the seers of the Merkavah, that every light appears like the flash of lightning — to the place from which they go, from there they return, in the sense of 'from there He will take you' (**Devarim 30:4**): specifically 'from there,' from the very lowest, he draws wholly close to Hashem." This is the se'if's David — "the beginning of the rungs of teshuvah," the healing that reaches even the one sunk lowest.

27 **Shmuel II 12:13**: After the affair of Bas-Sheva and Uriah (Shmuel II ch. 11), the prophet Nathan came to David, told him the parable of the poor man's ewe lamb, and declared, "You are the man!" (12:7), decreeing that "the sword shall never depart from your house" (12:10). David answered: " וַיֹּאמֶר דָּוִד אֶל־נָתָן: חָטָאתִי לַה'. " — "David said to Nathan: 'I have sinned against Hashem.' And Nathan said to David: 'Hashem, too, has removed your sin; you shall not die'" (**Shmuel II 12:13**). Radak explains that "also (*gam*)" comes to include David's confession — "as you confess, so too He has accepted your teshuvah"; and "you shall not die" means "not the death of the wicked, whose soul descends to Gehinnom — though you will still be punished in this world," namely the death of the child, Avshalom's rebellion, and "the sword shall not depart from your house." It is upon this instantaneous exchange — a single confession met at once with "Hashem has removed your sin" — that Chazal call David "the man who raised up the yoke of teshuvah" (**Avodah Zarah 5a**); cf. **Shabbos 56a**, "whoever says David sinned is merely mistaken," and **Shabbos 30a**, that the full manifestation of his atonement was withheld in his lifetime. Izhbitz on David's purification. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Writings, **Tehillim 51:1**, comments on David's plea " תחטאני באזוב ואטהר." He distinguishes a supernal purification in which Hashem illuminates the depth of the heart so that the person recognizes that he was bound to Him even in the hour of sin, from the more constricted purification of the ezov, given to the most distant forms of tumah. The latter requires extreme self-contraction, recognition of lowliness, and sweeping away every trace of ga'avah. David, the Mei HaShiloach says, longed so intensely for taharah that he was prepared for either path: like a man covered in filth who says to his friend, cleanse me with whatever broom you choose, only cleanse and purify me. "תחטאני באזוב" therefore expresses not self-justification but a willingness to undergo the deepest birur. That teaching is important for reading the Izhbitz-Radzin doctrine of yedi'ah and bechirah in connection with David. The higher disclosure — that even during the sin the deepest neshama had never ceased to be attached to Hashem — is a result of purification, not a permission granted beforehand to follow desire. Before the birur, David's avodah is confession, brokenness, and readiness for correction. Only after that can there be a revelation of a level on which the root-attachment was never severed. Shem MiShmuel repeatedly cites the Zohar on "גם ה' העביר חטאתך לא תמות" as referring to the removal of the destructive accuser generated by sin. In **Nitzavim 2:15** and **Sukkos 3:2-3**, he explains that the sin itself creates a prosecuting force that closes the heart; through true vidui and teshuvah that force is "passed away" so the person can again turn toward Hashem. This fits R' Tzadok's exact wording of the first rung. "Hashem has removed your sin; you shall not die" is genuine and immediate healing — the death-

כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּשַׁבָּת (ל׳ עֲמוּד א׳): "בְּחַיֶּיךָ אֵינִי מוֹדִיעַ וְכוּ׳".[29] — **as they said in Shabbat (30a): "In your lifetime I will not make it known, etc.",** כִּי אָז לֹא נִתְגַּלָּה עֲדַיִן מַדְרֵגָה זוֹ שֶׁל תְּשׁוּבָה — **For at that era this higher level of repentance had not yet been revealed,**

כִּי יְדוּעַ "אַבָּא יָסַד בָּרַתָּא", — **for it is known that "the Father founded the Daughter" (Chochmah founds Malchut),** וְיסוֹדוֹ שֶׁל דָּוִד הַמֶּלֶךְ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם נִצְמַח מֵאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם — **and King David's foundation sprouted from Abraham our father, peace be upon him,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה (בְּרֵאשִׁית רַבָּה מ״א, ה׳): "הֵיכָן מְצָאתִיו? בִּסְדוֹם". — **as our Sages of blessed memory stated (Bereishit Rabbah 41:5): "Where did I find him? In Sodom."**

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bearing obstruction is removed — even though the later punishments in David's life show that the complete revelation of retroactive tikkun has not yet arrived.

28 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §164**): "In the reckoning of people the baal teshuvah is not seen as a complete tzaddik… because teshuvah is called '*alma de-iskasya*' the concealed world, and its preciousness and beauty are not revealed to people" — even though the Sages taught, "in the place where baalei teshuvah stand the wholly righteous cannot stand" (**Berachos 34b**). He likens it to Leah, who "was hated" and wept — the hidden secret of teshuvah — against Rachel of "revealed beauty"; yet the essential offspring are from Leah, "for the essence of birth, the renewal of Torah and of souls by God's will, is all through the rung of teshuvah." This illuminates why David's face was whitened at the mention of his sin, and why the higher rung — full rectification of the past, with no shame at all — "was not yet revealed in his lifetime": teshuvah's beauty belongs to the *concealed* world. Izhbitz-Radzin parallel to Leah as alma d'iskasya. Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayetzei 63:1, explicitly describes the zivug of Yaakov and Leah as "עלמא דאתכסיא," above ordinary human grasp. Rachel's beauty and the stature of her children are visible on the surface; Leah and her children repeatedly require later birur. Yehudah and Tamar, Reuven and Bilhah, and other episodes can look compromised at the moment of occurrence while their inner place in the Divine plan emerges only later. That is exactly the phenomenology R' Tzadok assigns to teshuvah: its "yofi" is concealed because the present observer still sees the broken history, whereas the deeper birur by which that history becomes the vehicle of a higher birth is not yet visible. Beis Yaakov, Vayetzei 66:2, develops the same point through Leah's naming of Yehudah. On the surface she appears to have received Yehudah without the same visible struggle as the earlier children, yet "אין הקב"ה נותן בחנם רק על ידי יגיעה"; her hidden labor in the first three births is gathered into the fourth. Therefore she says "הפעם אודה את ה'," and the Midrash's "Leah grasped hoda'ah, and her children opened with hoda'ah" becomes a principle: what appeared externally unearned or even unattractive is later disclosed as the fruit of hidden avodah. R' Tzadok's equation of Leah with teshuvah is thus thoroughly Ishbitzian: the baal teshuvah belongs to a world in which the truth of a life cannot be read from its first visible form. This also explains the David connection. David descends from Leah through Yehudah, and his own teshuvah remains an "alma d'iskasya" in his lifetime: forgiven, yet publicly shamed; inwardly rooted in the future Malchus, yet without the visible vindication that comes only through Shlomo. The concealed-world pattern of Leah becomes the historical pattern of Davidic teshuvah.

29 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §158**): "Through *mesirus nefesh* unto death in one's very thought, in complete truth — that he consents in his heart that if it be God's will and better for him to die, he desires it willingly — he is saved from the decree of death… for his thought and his acceptance upon himself is *reckoned as the deed itself*, and it is thereafter as though he had come in a second *gilgul* to this world, knowing what he had spoiled in the first, and able to *rectify it*; and there is no sin that cannot thus be mended." This is the very mechanism of §1-3's higher rung — "the root of Israel that can change even the past": the wholehearted giving-over of the *nefesh* (the "blood" that is the *nefesh*) sets a man, as it were, in a new life over against his old, from which he can reach back and heal what was.

Shabbos 30a: David asked for a sign that his sin was forgiven; God replied, "In your lifetime I will not make it known; in the lifetime of your son Shlomo I will make it known." When Shlomo brought the Ark into the Holy of Holies and the gates would not open, he was answered only when he invoked "remember the kindnesses of David Your servant" — "at that moment the faces of all David's enemies turned black, and all knew that God had forgiven him." R' Tzadok: the *retroactive* rectification (removing all shame) was not manifest in David's own lifetime, for that higher rung had not yet been revealed.

Sources: Shabbos 30a

סעיף ד · Se'if 4

The theme: David's root runs back to Avraham, who began as "first of the converts" and only afterward revealed himself as father of the nation. Because Yitzchak was born to him, and the branch is contained in the root, the whole of Knesses Yisrael was folded into him. This is "the root of Israel" — a root cleaving to God with no dross at all, so that sins are incidental to it, thorns standing around a rose.

(ד) וְיסוֹד דַּרְגָּא דְּאַבְרָהָם אֲבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הוּא — **And the foundational rung of Abraham our father, peace be upon him, is,** שֶׁהָיָה תְּחִלָּה לַגֵּרִים — **that he was the first among converts,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בַּחֲגִיגָה (ג׳ עַמּוּד א׳). — **as they stated in Chagigah (3a).** רַק אַחַר כָּךְ, מִשֶּׁנּוֹלַד יִצְחָק וְאִתְכְּלִיל בּוֹ, — **Only afterward, once Isaac was born and integrated into him,** זָכָה לְשֵׁם אֵיתָן הָאֶזְרָחִי — **did he merit the name Ethan the Ezrachite,**

שֶׁהִבְטִיחוֹ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא: "מֵרֶחֶם מִשְׁחָר לְךָ טַל יַלְדֻתֶךָ". — **as the Holy One promised him (Psalms 110:3): "From the womb of the dawn, yours is the dew of your youth."** לִהְיוֹת כְּאֶזְרָח בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל — **becoming like a native-born Israelite,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּבְרֵאשִׁית רַבָּה עַל פָּסוּק זֶה (בְּפָרָשָׁה ל״ט): — **As they expounded in Bereishit Rabbah on this verse (Parashah 39): ",** הֵאמַר שֶׁיֵּשׁ בְּיָדַי עָוֹן וְכוּלְיָ", וְהוּא כְּלַפֵּי שֶׁהִקְדִּים "מֵרֶחֶם עַיֵּין שָׁם — **"Could it be that I have sin on my hands?" etc.; see there,** מִשְׁחָר", — **and this relates to the phrase "from the womb of the dawn,".**

וְדָרְשׁוּ שָׁם מֵרַחֲמוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, עַיֵּין שָׁם בְּמַתְנוֹת כְּהֻנָּה — **which they expounded as from the womb of the universe, see there in Matnot Kehunah.** הַיְינוּ דְּבָאֱמֶת גַּם אַבְרָהָם אֲבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הָיָה קָדוֹשׁ מֵרֶחֶם[30] — **This means that in truth Abraham our father, peace be upon him, was also holy from the womb,** וּמִתְּחִלַּת בְּרִיָּתוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם — **and from the very beginning of the world's creation,** וְרַק תְּחִלָּתוֹ הָיְתָה כְּגֵר — **and it was merely his initial appearance that was like a convert;** אֲבָל אַחַר כָּךְ זָכָה לְגַלּוֹת שָׁרְשׁוֹ — **but afterward he merited to reveal his inner root,**

שֶׁהוּא אֲבִי הָעוֹלָם וְשׁוֹרֶשׁ הָאֻמָּה הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִית כֻּלָּהּ, — **that he is the father of the world and the root of the entire Jewish nation,** שֶׁהוּא הַתְּחָלַת יַחַס זֶה דְּשׁוֹרֶשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל — **which is the inception of this lineage of Israel's root.** שֶׁיּוּכַל לְשַׁנּוֹת הַקּוֹדֶם גַּם כֵּן — **whereby one is empowered to alter the past as well.** וְדָבָר זֶה הָיָה אַחַר אֲשֶׁר אַבְרָהָם הוֹלִיד אֶת יִצְחָק — **And this occurred after Abraham fathered Isaac,** שֶׁהוּא קָדוֹשׁ מֵרֶחֶם וְנִמּוֹל לִשְׁמוֹנָה — **who was holy from the womb and circumcised on the eighth day,**

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30 **Tehillim 110:3**: "עַמְּךָ נְדָבֹת בְּיוֹם חֵילֶךָ, בְּהַדְרֵי קֹדֶשׁ מֵרֶחֶם מִשְׁחָר, לְךָ טַל יַלְדֻתֶיךָ" — a verse whose plain meaning is famously difficult. Rashi reads the psalm as addressed to Avraham: "your people will volunteer on the day of your host" — when Avraham mustered his men to pursue the four kings (Bereishis 14), Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre going out with him of their own accord; "in the beauty of holiness, from the womb" — in the merit of the holiness that was in him from his mother's womb, for "he recognized his Creator at the age of three" (**Nedarim 32a**); and "yours is the dew of your youth *lecha tal yaldusecha*" — "your youth shall be reckoned to you: the ways of uprightness by which you conducted yourself in your youth will be to you as pleasant as this dew." R' Tzadok links this to the Midrash (**Bereishis Rabbah 39**) that Avraham feared, "shall I say that there is sin in my hand?" and was told, "מֵרַחֲמוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם שִׁחַרְתִּיךָ לִי" — "From the womb of the world I sought you for Myself": Avraham was in truth holy from the womb, so that his *beginning* as a convert — the "youth" preceding the revealing of his root — is itself like dew, pure and pleasant, and no taint.
Bereishis Rabbah 39:8 (on **Tehillim 110:3**, "yours is the dew of your youth"): "Avraham feared and said: shall I say I have sin in my hand, that I served idols all these years? God said: 'yours is the dew of your youth' — just as dew evaporates, so your sins evaporate." The Midrash reads *merechem mishachar*: " מֵרַחֲמוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם שִׁחַרְתִּיךָ לִי" — "From the womb of the world I sought you for Myself"; R' Tzadok reads this as Avraham's holiness from the beginning of the world's creation. R' Tzadok: Avraham was in essence holy from the womb; the "convert" phase was only his beginning.

וְאַבְרָהָם הוּא הַמּוֹלִיד זֶה[31] — **and Abraham being the one who fathered him,** מְמֵילָא גַּם הוּא שָׁרְשׁוֹ כֵּן — **consequently his root was likewise such,** מֵאַחַר שֶׁהוּא הֵבִיא דֶּבֶר זֶה דְּשׁוֹרֶשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל בָּעוֹלָם[32] — **since he brought forth this reality of Israel's root into the world.** שֶׁלֹּא הָיָה עֲדַיִן בַּמְּצִיאוּת בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה כְּלָל — **which had not previously existed in physical reality in this world at all.** וְעַל כֵּן אָמְרוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה (בְּרֵאשִׁית רַבָּה ס״ג, ב׳) — **Therefore our Sages of blessed memory stated (Bereishit Rabbah 63:2)**

דְּיַעֲקֹב פָּדָה אֶת אַבְרָהָם מִכִּבְשַׁן הָאֵשׁ, — **that Jacob redeemed Abraham from the fiery furnace,** רָצָה לוֹמַר שֹׁרֶשׁ יַעֲקֹב שֶׁהָיָה בּוֹ, — **meaning the root of Jacob that was contained within him,** כִּי שֶׁיִּצָּא הוּא כּוֹלֵל כֻּלָּם אַחַר שֶׁזָּכָה לְהוֹלִיד — **for he includes them all once he merited to father them;** הֲרֵי נִכְלַל עַל כָּרְחֵךְ בּוֹ כָּל אוֹתוֹ שַׁלְשֶׁלֶת מִמֶּנּוּ שַׁלְשֶׁלֶת זוֹ, — **and since this lineage emerged from him,** — **perforce that entire chain was integrated within him.**

כִּי אֵין הַדָּבָר נוֹתֵן מַה שֶּׁאֵין בּוֹ, — **For a cause cannot impart what it does not contain,** וּלְעוֹלָם הֶעָנָף כָּלוּל בַּשֹּׁרֶשׁ — **and the branch is always contained within the root.** וְהַבָּנִים גְּנוּזִים כֹּחָם בָּאָבוֹת[33] — **and the potential of the children is concealed within the fathers.** וּכְשֶׁנִּתּוֹסַף בּוֹ הַהֵ״א — **And when the letter Hei was added to his name,** הוּא ה״א אַחֲרוֹנָה דְּהַשֵּׁם הָרוֹמֵז לְכְנֶסֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל — **which corresponds to the final Hei of the Tetragrammaton alluding to Knesset Yisrael,**

נִכְלַל בּוֹ כָּל שׁוֹרֶשׁ כְּנֶסֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל שֶׁבְּכָל הַדּוֹרוֹת[34] — **the entire root of Knesset Yisrael throughout all generations was incorporated in him,** וְאָז זָכָה לְהוֹלִיד — **and then he merited to father.** וּלְהוֹצִיא אוֹתוֹ שׁוֹרֶשׁ שֶׁנִּשְׁתָּרֵשׁ בְּכֹחוֹ מֵהַכֹּחַ לַפּוֹעַל — **and to bring forth from potential into actuality that root embedded within his power.** וְשׁוֹרֶשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל הוּא דְּשָׁרְשָׁם דָּבוּק בַּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ וְאֵין שָׁם פְּסֹלֶת כְּלָל — **And the root of Israel is, that their root is bound to Hashem, blessed be He, containing no dross whatsoever.**

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31 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Machshavos Charutz §11**): "Avraham Avinu, who is called 'first of the converts' (**Chagigah 3a**) — it is brought that he 'bound the twenty-two letters of the Torah on his tongue,' that he merited at first only the letters of speech, until he fathered Yitzchak, and after the tenth trial, when Yitzchak was 'incorporated' within him — and this was on Rosh Hashanah, as they said (**Rosh Hashanah 10a**) that Sarah was remembered, that is, in conception, from which time he is called 'father.'" This is the se'if's Avraham: he *began* as a *ger*, and only once he fathered Yitzchak did he reveal his root as father of the nation.

32 **Chagigah 3a**: "שֶׁהָיָה תְּחִילָּה לְגֵרִים" — "he was the first of the converts." R' Tzadok: Avraham's own starting-point was that of a *ger*, and only after fathering Yitzchak did he reveal his deeper root as native-born father of Israel. Avraham's transition from ger to root-father in Chassidus. Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 24:1, portrays Avraham after milah, Akeidah, and the ten nisyonos as a person transformed "מהיפך להיפך" in the manner of a ger. Yet the very same transformation reveals, rather than manufactures, the depth for which he was created. This is close to R' Tzadok's paradox: Avraham begins historically as the first ger, but after Yitzchak is included in him the earlier stage itself can be read from the standpoint of his native root as father of Israel. Kedushas Levi, Lech Lecha §37, similarly refuses to define Avraham by Terach. Using "ger shenisgayer ke-katan shenolad," he argues that Avraham's true av is the Divine middah and mission from which he is spiritually hewn — the revelation of Hashem's Name through the future Jewish people. Thus the ger-principle becomes not simply erasure of ancestry but discovery of a deeper ancestry. R' Tzadok pushes this one step farther: once Yitzchak and Yaakov are understood as already latent in Avraham, the branch discloses what was hidden in the root, and the past can be reread accordingly.

33 **Bereishis Rabbah 63:2**: "Yaakov redeemed Avraham" — the merit/root of Yaakov (whose "bed was whole," with no unfit offspring) was already contained within Avraham and "redeemed" him. R' Tzadok's principle: the branch is contained in the root, so the whole future nation was folded into Avraham once he fathered Yitzchak, all the more so when the *heh* of the Name (Knesses Yisrael) was joined to him (Avram → Avraham).

34 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §172**): "Just as there is, in place, the *even shesiyah* foundation stone from which the world was founded — and it is the root of the whole world — so among souls there is one soul that includes the whole generation, which is the *parnas ha-dor* leader of the generation; and likewise one that includes all the generations; and so too in time there is a time that includes all the days, which is the day of Shabbos." This illuminates Avraham's rung in the se'if: as "father of the world and root of the entire Israelite nation," he is the *even shesiyah* of Knesses Yisrael — the single root-soul in whom "all the root of Knesses Yisrael of every generation" is folded, so that "the branch is contained in the root" and even the past can be changed from within him.

כְּיַעֲקֹב אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם שֶׁמִּטָּתוֹ שְׁלֵימָה — **like Jacob our father, peace be upon him, whose bed was whole.** וְכָל הַחֲטָאִים אֵינָם בְּעֶצֶם רַק בְּמִקְרֶה — **And all sins are not intrinsic, but merely external incidents,** (הֲדַס הָעוֹמֵד בֵּין הַקּוֹצִים כְּאַסָא דְּקָאֵי בֵּינֵי הוּצֵי[35] — **like a myrtle standing among thorns** (מ״ד עַמּוּד א׳), שֶׁהִמְשִׁילוּ רַבּוֹתֵינוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה בְּסַנְהֶדְרִין, — **as our Sages of blessed memory allegorized in Sanhedrin (44a),** וְקוֹצִים הַסּוֹבְבִים אֶת הַשּׁוֹשַׁנָּה — **and like thorns surrounding a rose,**

שֶׁיּוּכְלוּ לַחְתּוֹךְ הַקּוֹצִים וְהַהוּצִי — **where one can sever the thorns and briars,** וְתִשָּׁאֵר הָאַסָא וְהַשּׁוֹשַׁנָּה נְקִיָּה וּשְׁלֵימָה לְגַמְרֵי כַּאֲשֶׁר הִיא בְּעַצְמוּתָהּ.[36] — **and the myrtle and the rose will remain completely pure and intact as they are in their true essence.**

סעיף ה · Se’if 5

The theme: Rectifying the past is the higher rung; the beginning of teshuvah is Avraham’s — bringing healing to the world at least from now on. Rectification of the past belongs to Israel alone, whose root is truly good; the nations have only a forward-healing, and even that does not endure with them. This first rung, however, embraces the entire world.

(ה) וְזֶהוּ תִּיקּוּן הַקּוֹדֶם שֶׁיְּבֻקַּשׁ עָוֹן יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאֵינֶנּוּ, — **And this is the rectification of the past where the sin of Israel will be sought and will not be found,** אֲבָל הַתְחָלַת הַתְּשׁוּבָה הוּא דַּרְגָּא דְּאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם — **however, the beginning of repentance is the level of Abraham our father, peace be upon him,** מִצַּד עַצְמוֹ וְשׁוֹרֶשׁ הַתְחָלַת עֲבוֹדָתוֹ, — **from his own vantage point and the root of the beginning of his service,** שֶׁהָיָה אָב לְכָל הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ — **wherein he was a father to the entire world.** לְהָבִיא רְפוּאָה לָעוֹלָם עַל כָּל פָּנִים מִכָּאן וּלְהַבָּא[37] — **to bring healing to the world at least from now and onward.**

דִּלְתַקֵּן הַקּוֹדֶם אִי אֶפְשָׁר בְּכָל הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ, — **For to rectify the past is impossible across the entire world,** שֶׁהָיוּ בְּיָמָיו גּוֹיִם וְלֹא נִתְּנָה תְּשׁוּבָה אֶלָּא לְיִשְׂרָאֵל — **who in his days were gentiles, and repentance was given exclusively to Israel,** דְּנִתְּנָה תּוֹרָה וְנִתְחַדְּשָׁה הִלְכוֹת תְּשׁוּבָה — **for the Torah was given and the laws of repentance were innovated (,** וּנְהִירְנָא דְּרָאִיתִי כֵּן לְהָרַב מְנַחֵם עֲזַרְיָה מִפָּאנוֹ בַּעֲשָׂרָה מַאֲמָרוֹת — **(and I recall seeing this in the work of Rabbeinu Menachem Azariah of Fano in Asarah Maamarot,** וּלְהָרַב יִצְחָק אַבְרַבַּנְאֵל בְּנַחֲלַת אָבוֹת — **and in the commentary of Don Isaac Abravanel in Nachalat Avot,**

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35 **Sanhedrin 44a**: On “Israel has sinned” (**Yehoshua 7:11**), R’ Abba bar Zavda said: “Even though he sinned, he is still Israel.” R’ Abba added the folk-adage: “a myrtle *asa* that stands among thorns *chilfei* — its name is myrtle and they call it myrtle.” R’ Tzadok: Israel’s sins are “thorns around the rose,” incidental and severable, never the essence of the root, which cleaves wholly to God.
Sources: Sanhedrin 44a · Yehoshua 7:11

36 R’ Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §131**): “The root of the souls of all Israel is from the Source of life… and this matter was first revealed in full clarity through Bilaam, whose entire passage concerns this virtue of Israel — that even should they pile sins one upon another, the love of the Holy One is *not severed from them by so much as a hair’s breadth*” (and Bilaam, who had no share in the World to Come, was its unwilling herald). This is the very point of “the root of Israel” in the se’if: the root “cleaves to Hashem with no dross at all,” so that the sins are but incidental thorns encircling the rose — they can be cut away and the rose “left wholly clean and whole, as it is in its own essence.”

37 **Yirmeyah 50:20**: בַּיָּמִים הָהֵם וּבָעֵת הַהִיא נְאֻם ה׳, יְבֻקַּשׁ אֶת עֲוֹן יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאֵינֶנּוּ, וְאֶת חַטֹּאת יְהוּדָה וְלֹא תִמָּצֶאינָה, כִּי “אֶסְלַח לַאֲשֶׁר אַשְׁאִיר” — “In those days and at that time, says Hashem, the iniquity of Israel shall be sought and there shall be none, and the sins of Judah and none shall be found; for I will pardon those I leave as a remnant.” The verse falls within Yirmeyah’s prophecy of the downfall of Bavel and the return of Israel (ch. 50): at that future time Israel’s sin is not merely forgiven but “sought and not found” — uprooted entirely. This is R’ Tzadok’s emblem for the highest rung of teshuvah, the rectification of the past itself. Radak explains that the verse must speak of the Messianic future — “for I will pardon” — since sinners still remained throughout the Second Temple and this present exile; and “to the remnant I leave” likewise points to that time, as in “he who remains in Zion and is left in Jerusalem shall be called holy” (**Yeshayah 4:3**) and “the remnant of Israel shall do no wrong” (**Tzefaniah 3:13**).

וְעוֹד קַדְמוֹנִים הַרְבֵּה כָּתְבוּ כֵּן בְּפָשְׁיטוּת — **and many other early authorities wrote this simply.** דְּאֵין תְּשׁוּבָה מוֹעֶלֶת לַגּוֹיִם — **that repentance does not avail for gentiles.** וְשׁוּב מָצָאתִי כֵּן מְפֹרָשׁ בַּתַּנְחוּמָא (פָּרָשַׁת הַאֲזִינוּ): — **And later I found this explicitly in the Midrash Tanchuma (Parashat Ha'azinu): ",** עוֹשֶׂה תְּשׁוּבָה נוֹשֵׂא לוֹ פָּנִים — **"He lifts His countenance to one who repents;** יָכוֹל לַכֹּל? תַּלְמוּד לוֹמַר: 'אֵלֶיךָ' – וְלֹא לְאָמָּה אַחֶרֶת". — **might this apply to all? Scripture teaches: 'unto you'—and not to any other nation."**

וּבְסֵפֶר דְּבַשׁ לְפִי (מַעֲרֶכֶת חֵי״ת אוֹת כ״ד) מֵבִיא זֶה בְּשֵׁם הַבִּינָה לַעִתִּים), — **And in Sefer Devash LeFi (section Chet, letter 24) he cites this in the name of the Binah LeIttim),** לְיִשְׂרָאֵל שֶׁשָּׁרְשָׁם בֶּאֱמֶת טוֹב — **unto Israel whose essential root is genuinely good.** דְּעַל כֵּן נִתְּנָה תּוֹרָה לָהֶם — **which is why the Torah was given to them. "** וְלֹא עָשָׂה כֵן לְכָל גּוֹי", — **"He did not do so for any other nation," (Psalms 147:20),** דְּאֵין לָהֶם שַׁיְּכוּת בַּשֹּׁרֶשׁ עִם הַתּוֹרָה — **for they have no intrinsic connection at the root with the Torah,**

עַל כֵּן לֹא שַׁיָּיךְ בָּהֶם דְּבָרִים שֶׁחִדְּשָׁה תּוֹרָה[38] — **therefore concepts innovated by the Torah do not apply to them,** וְאֵינָם אֶלָּא מִצַּד הַסֵּדֶר הָרָאוּי עַל פִּי הַחָכְמָה — **and they exist solely within the framework appropriate to natural wisdom.** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בַּיְרוּשַׁלְמִי (פֶּרֶק ב׳ דְּמַכּוֹת): "שְׁאֲלוּ לַחָכְמָה וְכוּ', עַיֵּין שָׁם — **as they stated in the Yerushalmi (Makkot, ch. 2): "They asked Wisdom, etc." examine there.** וְרַק רְפוּאָה לְהַבָּא זֶה יֵשׁ גַּם בַּגּוֹיִם — **And merely healing for the future does exist among gentiles as well,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב בְּנִינְוֵה כְּשֶׁשָּׁבוּ מִדַּרְכָּם — **as written concerning Nineveh when they turned back from their evil way,**

דְּעַל כָּל פָּנִים הִשְׁתָּא מִיהָת לֹא חָטְאוּ, — **that the decreed calamity was averted,** **since at least at that present moment they ceased sinning,** וּלְעוֹלָם עָוֹן עֲצָמוֹ אֵינוֹ נִמְחָק כְּלָל גַּבְיֵיהוּ. — **yet the sin itself is never erased in their case.** וְשׁוֹרֶשׁ אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם נִתְעוֹרֵר עַל יְדֵי זֶה — **And the root of Abraham our father, peace be upon him, was awakened through this.** לְרַפֵּא עַל כָּל פָּנִים לְכָל הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ לְהַבָּא — **to bring healing for the future at least to the entire world.**

אַף דְּלְעִנְיַן רְפוּאָה דְּלְהַבָּא גַּם כֵּן יֵשׁ חִלּוּק בֵּין יִשְׂרָאֵל לְאֻמּוֹת הָעוֹלָם — **Even though regarding future healing there also, is a distinction between Israel and the nations of the world,** דְּאֻמָּה אֵינָהּ רְפוּאָה הַמִּתְקַיֶּמֶת כְּלָל — **for with the nations it is not an enduring healing at all.** וּבְבֵירוּר סוֹף הַמַּכָּה לַחֲזוֹר וּלְהִתְגַּלּוֹת[39] — **and the wound is ultimately bound to reappear.** מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן "יִשְׂרָאֵל עַמְּךָ כֻּלָּם צַדִּיקִים", — **In contrast, regarding Israel, "Your people are all righteous,"**

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38 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Yisrael Kedoshim §5**): " וכל תפיסת עמלק הוא רק למראית העין כי אין לו שום שיכות ואחיזה לאמת" — "Amalek's entire grasp is only upon outward appearance, for he has no connection or hold upon the truth." When apparently fallen members of Israel were taken from beneath the cloud, that appearance did not disclose their true root: " דכלפי שמיא גליא מעמקי לבבם דלא ניתקו משורש קדשת ישראל. אפלו הגדיל עונות ביותר מכל מקום הוא עם לבדד ישכון ובגוים לא יתחשב" — "For before Heaven the depths of their hearts are revealed: they have not been severed from the root of Israel's holiness. Even if one has greatly multiplied sins, he nevertheless belongs to 'a people that dwells alone and is not reckoned among the nations.'" This clarifies R' Tzadok's premise here that Israel's root is truly good: the outward history of sin does not define that root, and teshuvah can return to it.

39 R' Tzadok — parallel (**Resisei Layla §54**): "Whereas the nations of the world — even should they repent — 'teshuvah was given only to Israel' (**Midrash Tanchuma Ha'azinu 4**); but for them there is no atonement at all, *for by them the sin is in its very essence be-etzem*." This is the ground of §1-5's ruling that among the nations "it is not an enduring healing, and in the end the wound is destined to reopen": the Torah's teshuvah was legislated for Israel alone — "whose root is truly good" — so their sins are but incidental thorns, whereas for the nations the sin cleaves to the essence itself, and even their "forward-healing" cannot hold. R' Tzadok there rests the point, exactly as the se'if does, on the same Tanchuma: "*to you* — and not to another nation."

וְנִקְרָא מִיָּד צַדִּיק גָּמוּר[40] — **and he is immediately called completely righteous,** לְהִיוֹת "דֶּרֶךְ צַדִּיקִים כְּאוֹר נֹגַהּ הוֹלֵךְ וְאוֹר וְגוֹמֵר",[41] — **such that "the path of the righteous is like the light of dawn that shines brighter and brighter,"** דְּהַתְחָלַת הִתְעוֹרְרוּת הִרְהוּר תְּשׁוּבָה בַּלֵּב — **for the initial awakening of a thought of repentance in the heart** פּוֹעֵל לִהְיוֹת מוֹסִיף וְהוֹלֵךְ. — **acts to grow and expand progressively.** אֲבָל דָּבָר זֶה הוּא מִצַּד מַדְרֵגוֹת הָעֲתִידוֹת — **However, that trajectory belongs to future higher rungs,**

אֲבָל מַדְרֵגָה זוֹ דִּתְשׁוּבָה בִּרְפוּאָה לְהַבָּא עַל שֶׁעָבַר לְבַד — **whereas this baseline level of repentance providing future healing alongside mere pardon for the past,** זֶה כּוֹלֵל כָּל הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ.[42] — **encompasses the entire world.**

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40 R' Tzadok — parallel (Poked Akarim §4): "All the creation of the world is for the sake of man, to serve in it and bring forth its abundance; and this too was blurred and spoiled through what people spoiled in their deeds. But 'your people are all righteous — forever they shall inherit the land' (**Yeshayah 60:21**): an eternal inheritance that has no cessation or spoiling — for they are called 'the remnant of Yosef.'" This is the se'if's contrast: Israel's healing is *enduring* ("an inheritance with no cessation"), whereas the nations' forward-healing is destined to reopen.

41 **Yeshayah 60:21**: "וְעַמֵּךְ כֻּלָּם צַדִּיקִים, לְעוֹלָם יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ, נֵצֶר מַטָּעַי מַעֲשֵׂה יָדַי לְהִתְפָּאֵר" — "And your people, all of them righteous, shall inherit the land forever; the branch of My planting, the work of My hands, in which I take glory." From Yeshayah's prophecy of the future redemption of Tzion (ch. 60). R' Tzadok cites it to contrast Israel with the nations: because at their root "your people are all righteous," a Jew is called a complete tzaddik the instant the stirring of teshuvah begins. Rashi (on *lehispa'er*): "that I shall take glory in them." And the Mishnah (**Sanhedrin 90a**, Perek Chelek) makes this verse the prooftext that "all Israel have a share in the World to Come, as it is said, 'and your people are all righteous, they shall inherit the land forever.'" The phrase "ועמך כולם צדיקים" receives a striking Chassidic complement in **Tanya ch. 2**. If the neshama of Israel is "chelek Eloka mima'al mamash," then the prophetic designation "all of your people are righteous" can be read as a statement about root-identity rather than a denial of actual transgression. The revealed personality can become entangled in sin, while the second, Divine soul remains the inner source to which teshuvah returns. Sefas Emes, **Rosh HaShanah 25:4**, expresses the same distinction in terms of two loves. There is an ahavah awakened by mitzvos and good deeds, and there is the essential love of Israel rooted in "chelek Hashem amo," which is not dependent on a particular deed and cannot be extinguished by "many waters." Sin obscures the manifestation of the neshama; teshuvah causes it to awaken again. Thus R' Tzadok's use of "ועמך כולם צדיקים" is not sentimental: it is the ontological premise that allows teshuvah to uncover a righteousness deeper than the historical act.

42 Yerushalmi **Makkos 2:6**: "They asked Wisdom: what is the sinner's punishment? It said, 'evil pursues sinners' (**Mishlei 13:21**). They asked Prophecy: 'the soul that sins shall die' (**Yechezkel 18:4**). They asked the Holy One: 'let him do teshuvah and it will atone for him.'" — Tanchuma, Ha'azinu: "One who does teshuvah, He shows him favor — one might think for all nations; Scripture says 'to you' — and not to another nation." R' Tzadok marshals these (with the Ramma and Abarbanel) that the Torah's *innovation* of teshuvah-that-rectifies-the-past was given to Israel alone; the nations have only "healing going forward" (as at Nineveh). Chassidic explanation of why teshuvah belongs uniquely to the root of Israel. **Shem MiShmuel, Ki Seitzei 2:17**, writes that the effectiveness of teshuvah for Israel is bound to their essential connection to Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov. Jewish souls are "בעצם נפשות טהורות וטובות" — intrinsically pure and good — and aveiros are a contingent soiling. When a Jew returns, the inner point reconnects with the chain reaching the Avos and a new current of life can flow from the root. This is nearly the same metaphysical distinction R' Tzadok draws here between sin that is incidental to a good shoresh and sin that belongs to an essence lacking that root. **Tanya, Likkutei Amarim ch. 2** (2:1), supplies the Chabad formulation of the same root claim: "ונפש השנית בישראל היא חלק אלוה ממעל ממש." The Divine soul of Israel is not merely an ethically improved personality but a soul whose deepest origin is Godly. On this account teshuvah can be more than behavioral correction: return is literally return to the soul's own source. R' Tzadok's language remains his own and should not be collapsed into Tanya's system, but the comparison clarifies why a Jewish past can ultimately be healed from within: the deepest subject of that past was never identical with the sin.

סעיף ו · Se’if 6

The theme: This is the middah of Chesed, which is expansion — and it reaches forward only. Forgiveness from Chesed presupposes that a sin exists and is pardoned, so a residue of shame remains. To be as though one had never sinned is impossible from this side: Chesed is expansion without force, and the heart’s first stirring is broad but not yet strong.

(ו) וְזֶהוּ מִדַּת הַחֶסֶד שֶׁהוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְּׁטוּת — **And this is the attribute of Chesed (Lovingkindness) which operates through expansive outreach (,** וּמִדָּת "וְרַב חֶסֶד" הוּא רִבּוּי יוֹתֵר דְּנוֹשֵׂא עָוֹן גַּם בְּלֹא תְּשׁוּבָה — **(and the attribute “abundant in kindness” is a greater surplus that bears sin even without repentance,** עַיֵּין בְּהָרִי״ף פֶּרֶק קַמָּא דְּרֹאשׁ הַשָּׁנָה — **see in the Rif in the first chapter of Rosh Hashanah,** וְגַם שָׁם מִכָּל מָקוֹם עָוֹן עַצְמוֹ אֵינוֹ נִמְחָק — **and even there, the sin itself is nonetheless not erased,** עַיֵּין שָׁם בְּהָרִי״ף בְּשֵׁם גָּאוֹן — **see there in the Rif in the name of a Gaon,**

דְּתָנָא דְּבֵי רַבִּי יִשְׁמָעֵאל גַּם כֵּן לְפָרֵשׁ מִדַּת רַב חֶסֶד אִתֵּי, יְעַיֵּין שָׁם). — **that the school of Rabbi Ishmael also comes to expound the attribute of abundant kindness, examine there).** וּמִכָּל מָקוֹם אֵינוֹ אֶלָּא לְהַבָּא — **And nonetheless it pertains only from here onward,** כִּי הַסְּלִיחָה שֶׁמִּצַּד הַחֶסֶד הָרֵי יֵשׁ עָוֹן — **for in the forgiveness that stems from Chesed, sin still exists in reality,** רַק שֶׁהַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא בְּרוֹב חֲסָדָיו הוּא מוֹחֵל וְסוֹלֵחַ.[43] — **save that the Holy One, blessed be He, in the abundance of His kindness pardons and forgives.** וּכְמוֹ מִי שֶׁחָטָא נֶגֶד חֲבֵירוֹ וּמְבַקְּשׁוֹ לִמְחוֹל — **And it is comparable to one who offended his fellow and beseeches him to forgive.**

דְּאִם אֵינוֹ אַכְזָרִי מוֹחֵל מִיָּד — **who, if not cruel, forgives at once.** (וְאָמְרוּ בְּיוֹמָא (פ״ז עַמּוּד א׳ — **And they said in Yoma (87a),** דְּאֵין צָרִיךְ לְבַקֵּשׁ יוֹתֵר מִשָּׁלֹשׁ פְּעָמִים — **that one need not plead more than three times,** כִּי יֵשׁ בָּזֶה כְּדֵי פִּיּוּס לְכָל אָדָם — **for this provides sufficient appeasement for any human being.** וּלְאִישׁ טוֹב וְחָסֶד וַדַּאי דַּי בְּפַעַם אַחַת — **and for a man of goodness and kindness, one time certainly suffices.**

וְכָל שֶׁכֵּן לְמִדַּת חַסְדּוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שֶׁהוּא לְאֵין שִׁיעוּר — **And all the more so regarding His attribute of kindness which is infinite,** וַדַּאי בַּחֲרָטָה כָּל דְּהוּא דַּי לְפָנָיו — **certainly the slightest twinge of remorse suffices before Him,** וּבְבַקָּשָׁה קַלָּה דְּ"סְלַח לָנוּ" וְגוֹמֵר דַּי שֶׁהוּא מוֹחֵל וְסוֹלֵחַ לְאַלְתַּר — **and with a simple plea of “Forgive us, etc.” it is sufficient that He pardons and forgives immediately.** וְהוּא כְּצַדִּיק גָּמוּר — **and the penitent is treated as completely righteous.** אֶלָּא דְּמִכָּל מָקוֹם יֵשׁ בּוּשָׁה עֲדַיִן[44] — **However, there is nonetheless residual shame,**

וּכְמוֹ בִּבְנֵי אָדָם, אַף שֶׁמָּחַל לוֹ, — **and as among human beings, even when one has forgiven.** כָּל זְמַן שֶׁמַּזְכִּירִים לוֹ מִתְבַּיֵּישׁ מִזֶּה — **whenever it is mentioned to the offender he feels ashamed.** וְדָבָר זֶה שֶׁיִּהְיֶה כְּאִלּוּ לֹא חָטָא מֵעוֹלָם — **And this outcome—that it should be as though he never sinned at all—,** זֶה אִי אֶפְשָׁר כְּשֶׁהַסְּלִיחָה מִצַּד מִדַּת הַחֶסֶד[45] — **is impossible when forgiveness proceeds from**

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43 **Rif, Rosh Hashanah 4a** (on **Bavli Rosh Hashanah 17a**; the Thirteen Attributes): “ נושא עון ועובר על פשע — תנא דבי רבי ישמעאל: מעביר ראשון ראשון וכך היא המדה” — “‘Bearing iniquity and passing over transgression’ — the school of R’ Yishmael taught: He passes over the first sins, one by one; and such is His measure.” The Gemara adds (Rava): “but the sin itself is not erased — for if his sins are a majority, it is reckoned among them.” R’ Tzadok: even *rav chesed*, which bears sin without teshuvah, only “passes over” — it does not erase the sin’s essence.

44 **Yoma 87a**: “One who seeks pardon from his fellow need not ask more than three times” (for that suffices as appeasement). R’ Tzadok: a fortiori before God, whose kindness is boundless — the slightest remorse and a light request (“forgive us”) bring immediate pardon; yet this *Chesed*-forgiveness still leaves residual “shame,” which only the higher, *Gevurah*-rooted teshuvah (the coming simanim) removes.

45 R’ Tzadok — parallel (**Tzidkas HaTzadik §242**): “Teshuvah is like the *hataras chacham* a Sage’s release of a vow, which *uproots the matter retroactively le-mafrea*, so that the evil angel formed from the sin is nullified entirely; whereas teshuvah from love, by which sins become as merits, means not that the sin is nullified but that it is *transformed* to good — and these are two rungs, *le-is’hapcha* to transform and *le-ischafya* to subdue.” This lays bare precisely what §1-6’s *Chesed*-forgiveness lacks: Chesed only pardons a sin

the attribute of Chesed. וְכֵן כְּשֶׁהַתְּשׁוּבָה מִצַּד אוֹתָהּ מִדָּה — **and likewise when repentance operates from that attribute.**

כִּי הֵם שְׁתֵּי מִדּוֹת – גְּדֻלָּה וּגְבוּרָה, שֶׁהֵם שְׁנֵי הֲפָכִים — **For these are two distinct attributes—Gedulah (Greatness/Chesed) and Gevurah (Might/Discipline)—which are two opposites,** וּגְדֻלָּה הוּא הִתְפַּשְׁטוּת בְּגוֹדֶל, אֲבָל אֵינוֹ בִּגְבוּרָה וְכֹחַ. — **and Gedulah is expansive breadth, yet lacking contracted force and focused strength.** וְהַתְחָלַת כָּל עִנְיָן הוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת — **And the beginning of every process is in expansive outreach,** וְאַחַר כָּךְ מַתְחִיל לְהִתְגַּבֵּר בּוֹ, — **and afterward one begins to consolidate with power.** וְאָז הַהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת מְצֻטְמְצֶם עַל יְדֵי הַהִתְגַּבְּרוּת וְהַהִתְחַזְּקוּת — **and then the expansive breadth is concentrated through strengthening and discipline.**

וְכֵן הַתְחָלַת הִרְהוּר תְּשׁוּבָה בְּלֵב אָדָם — **So too the initial thought of repentance in a person's heart,** שֶׁאֵינוֹ עֲדַיִן בִּגְבוּרַת הַלֵּב בְּכֹחַ אַמִּיץ וְחָזָק שֶׁלֹּא יִנָּתֵק — **which does not yet possess the heart's formidable strength that cannot be severed,** אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁהוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת יוֹתֵר — **even though it has wide outreach,** מִכָּל מָקוֹם אֵין כֹּחוֹ חָזָק כָּל כָּךְ, — **nevertheless its power is not so firmly entrenched,** וְעַל כֵּן מֵבִיא רַק רְפוּאָה לְהַבָּא — **and therefore it brings healing only from here onward,**

דְּמִזֶּה לֹא יִמָּלֵט אֲפִילּוּ תְּשׁוּבָה הַיּוֹתֵר קַלָּה — **from which not even the lightest level of repentance falls short,** וּמִיָּד בְּהַתְחָלָתָהּ זֶה גְּדוּלָּתָהּ. — **and immediately at its onset, this constitutes its greatness.**

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that still *exists* (hence "forward" only, and "shame remains"), whereas the higher, forceful rung *uproots it from its origin* — as though it had never been — which is why "to be as if he had never sinned at all is impossible when the forgiveness is from the side of *Chesed*."